The titular story in Namita Gokhale's *Life on Mars: Collected Stories* follows a woman who befriends an unusual young man the same age as her emotionally distant sons. The story derives its name from a passage where Gokhale makes a poignant connection between the stereotypical imagery of Martians as 'little green men', and a group of doctors in their green-hued scrubs, huddled around the woman as she enters the hospital.

"Before I knew it, I was in hospital, being wheeled around on a rattling trolley—well, not a trolley but a stretcher, and there were arc lights and men in green overalls wearing masks. As the anaesthesia got to me, I discovered that I was on Mars, there were masked men in green overalls everywhere, and life on Mars wasn't really so different from life in Delhi. It was difficult, tedious and painful."

It's a particularly clever narrative gambit also because the woman's new friend, Udit Narain, is a "genuine crank", a conspiracy theorist who would no doubt chuckle at his friend invoking Martians in a relatively mundane medical situation. *Life on Mars* contains stories Gokhale wrote through the 1990s and the 2000s, as well as several new stories written in the last few years.

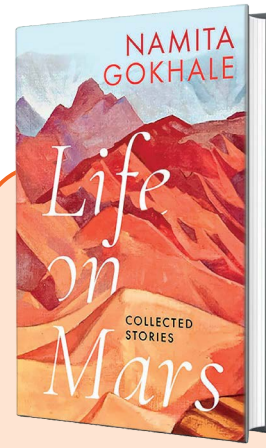
"The story 'Life on Mars' was written in the late 1990s," says Gokhale, who is also co-founder of the Jaipur Literature Festival. "It was written at a time when I was getting back to writing fiction after a while. I had been commissioned for a short story and when I started writing with a blank slate in my mind, the character of Udit Narain just came to me. He was based on someone I knew and was fond of. But most people thought of him as a crank."

In fact, a number of stories here feature characters inspired by people Gokhale knew down the years. As the opening line of 'GIGALIBB' (God is Great and Love is Bloody Blind) states, these stories "tread the slushy terrain between memory and fiction". For a writer, it's often tricky to calibrate just how much of real life you want in a fictional character sketch. To her credit, Gokhale does a fantastic job in this context. Virtually every line, every bit of dialogue or description tells us something unique and interesting about the character—or advances the plot along.

"The main character in the story 'Savithri and the Squirrels' was based on a woman who I was very fond of, and who was very fond of me," says Gokhale. "Similarly, with 'GIGALIBB', anybody who is from Nainital will identify who the story is about, the moment they read the line 'God is Great and Love is Bloody Blind'. But fiction cannot operate like an inside joke, I think. You have to make the character's motivations and their actions speak for themselves, without relying on any previous knowledge on the reader's part."

In one way or another, several stories here are studies in grief. Both 'Savithri and the Squirrels'—about an enigmatic woman working for a matchmaker—and 'GIGALIBB' fit this mould in a straightforward way. But there are other, subtler expressions of the same emotion, like 'The Day Princess Diana Died', my favourite story from the book. In this story, we see a kind of reverse Butterfly Effect—a truly 'big news' incident (in this case, the death of Lady Diana) having smaller, local consequences; the end of the protagonist's romantic relationship with a married man. Does every 'good' person have to mourn every death, even the death of a complete stranger on the other side of the world? Are all expressions of grief equally valid, or are some more equal than others, so to speak? This is a story that puts these complex questions before the reader in an artful and yet deceptively simple way.

Life on Mars ends with three Mahabharata stories, in a section called 'The Mirror of the Mahabharata'. Here she inhabits the voices of characters like Gandhari and Kunti, as they ponder the motives behind the main players' actions—and the consequences of



LIFE ON MARS
Collected Stories
By Namita Gokhale
SPEAKING TIGER
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The book is a great introduction to the style and philosophical preoccupations of one of our pre-eminent English-language writers